

Session 37: Jonah's Five-Word Sermon to the Ninevites

Key Takeaways

- Jonah's sermon is not typical of a prophet. It is only five words, and he doesn't warn the people or urge them to turn back to Yahweh like other Hebrew prophets.
- Jonah's sermon presents us with a comic contrast. Despite Jonah doing little to warn the people, they still turn back to Yahweh. This creates a strong contrast between the character of Jonah and the Ninevites.
- In the story, everyone is awake to God except Jonah.

Jonah's Five-Word Sermon

Jonah 3:4 NASB*

Yet forty days, and Nineveh is overturned (*nehpaket* / נִהְפַּכְתָּ).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The root *hapak* (הִפַּךְ) is overwhelmingly connected to the story of Sodom and Gomorrah's destruction throughout the Hebrew Bible.

Genesis 19:24-25, 29 NASB

²⁴ Then the LORD rained on Sodom and Gomorrah brimstone and fire from the LORD out of heaven, ²⁵ and he overthrew those cities, and all the valley, and all the inhabitants of the cities, and what grew on the ground. ... ²⁹ Thus it came about, when God destroyed the cities of the valley, that God remembered Abraham, and sent Lot out of the midst of the overthrow, when he overthrew the cities in which Lot lived.

Deuteronomy 29:23 NASB

All its land is brimstone and salt, a burning waste, unsown and unproductive, and no grass grows in it, like the overthrow of Sodom and Gomorrah, Admah and Zeboiim, which the LORD overthrew in his anger and in his wrath.

Isaiah 13:19 NASB

And Babylon, the beauty of kingdoms, the glory of the Chaldeans' pride, will be as when God overthrew Sodom and Gomorrah.

Jeremiah 49:17-18 NASB

¹⁷ "Edom will become an object of horror; everyone who passes by it will be horrified and will hiss at all its wounds. ¹⁸ Like the overthrow of Sodom and Gomorrah with its neighbors," says the LORD, "no one will live there, nor will a son of man reside in it."

Amos 4:10-11 NASB*

¹⁰ "I sent a plague among you after the manner of Egypt ... yet you have not repented to me," declares the LORD.

¹¹ "I overthrew you, as God overthrew Sodom and Gomorrah ... yet you have not repented to me," declares the LORD.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

However, the verb *hapak* can also be used in a more general sense of "turned over," and mean to transform or change.

Deuteronomy 23:5 NIV*

The LORD your God would not listen to Balaam but changed the curse into a blessing for you

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Amos 5:8 NASB

He who made the Pleiades and Orion,
and changes deep darkness into morning,
who also darkens day into night

Psalms 30:11 NIV

You changed my wailing into dancing;
you removed my sackcloth and clothed me with joy

1 Samuel 10:6 NASB

Then the Spirit of the LORD will come upon you mightily, and you shall prophesy with them and be changed into another man.

Interpretive Challenges with Jonah's Short Sermon

Jonah obeys the second divine commission to go to Nineveh, but does he announce the message God gave to him?

Jonah predicts the "overturning" of Nineveh within forty days, which he clearly intends as an announcement of destruction. If this was in fact Yahweh's message given to Jonah, it was either inaccurate or it failed to be fulfilled. If Yahweh's truthfulness is to be upheld, then there are a few logical options for interpretation (see Ray Lubeck, "[Prophetic Sabotage: A Look at Jonah 3:2-4](#)," 37-38).

A Conditional Threat

Jonah did deliver Yahweh's message exactly as he received it, but he, Yahweh, the Ninevites, and we as readers are meant to understand it as something else—a conditional threat that will not be carried out if Nineveh repents.

“That this was [Yahweh's] message ... is self-evident since it was the message which Jonah actually delivered.”

Zlotowitz, Meir (1980). [*Yonah: A New Translation With a Commentary Anthologized from Talmudic, Midrashic and Rabbinic Sources*](#). Messorah Publications. 119.

“[T]hese words are not what Jonah composed, but are exactly what Yahweh told him to say.”

Stuart, Douglas (1987). [*Word Biblical Commentary Vol. 31, Hosea-Jonah*](#). Thomas Nelson. 489.

Problem

The king clearly understands the oracle as an irreversible prediction of judgment ([3:8-9](#): “Let each man turn from his wicked way! Who knows, God might turn and relent!”). While prophets recognize that oracles of judgment might be averted by repentance ([Jer. 18:7-10](#)), those oracles are almost always accompanied by a call to repent.

A Justifiable Threat

Jonah delivered the message as given to him by God, but he knew beforehand that it was false (so he fled as he says in [4:2](#)). Yahweh never intended to execute this overturning, but his threat is justifiable on the grounds that it achieved a higher good, the repentance of the Ninevites.

“[T]he biblical story is not about a prophet but about an unfulfilled prophecy. God's wonderful graciousness here explains the failure of Jonah's prediction.”

Bickerman, Elias (1985). [*Four Strange Books of the Bible: Jonah, Daniel, Koheleth, Esther*](#). Schocken. 32.

“This is the mysterious paradox of Hebrew faith: The All-wise and Almighty may change a word that He proclaims.”

Heschel, Abraham J. (2001). [*The Prophets*](#). Harper Perennial Modern Classics. 28.

Problem

This interpretation technically makes Jonah a false prophet (a big deal in [Deuteronomy 18](#)), intentionally proclaiming a word he knows is not true. It also portrays God as bearing false witness.

An Abbreviated Sermon

Jonah did not utter the message Yahweh gave him but altered or abbreviated it to suit his own purposes. Instead of delivering an original, conditional message of judgment and repentance, Jonah stated the oracle so

that the Ninevites would understand it as a pronouncement of irrevocable judgment.

Problems

- This portrays Jonah as being in a state of continued rebellion and disobedience to God, which is entirely possible.
- “This portrays Jonah as distorting God’s word.” Exactly! Jonah is consistently portrayed as an unreliable character whose words evade every person who speaks with him (the sailors in [1:8-9](#) and God in [4:3-4](#) and [4:8-9](#)).

God Teaching Jonah

Jonah faithfully uttered the message, but God is continuing to “teach a lesson” to Jonah. The message is worded ambiguously so that Jonah will think “overturned” means “destroyed,” whereas God knows that it means “changed,” anticipating Nineveh’s response.

Problems (and Solutions)

- This view depicts God as a trickster who knows Jonah will be motivated by a message of destruction. But by capitalizing on the potential double meaning, God can be faithful to the word of the prophet while also overcoming Jonah’s hatred.
- This “divine trick” prepares us for the next lesson for Jonah in chapter 4: the vine, the worm, and the wind.

“The ambiguity of ‘overturned’ amounts to a kind of pun. The word can mean to overthrow and destroy, but also to turn over, around, so that one thing becomes another ... Some such transformation or conversion ... seems to be what the Lord had in mind, if indeed these are the exact words given to Jonah to speak. So it may be that the Lord has fooled Jonah, giving him a message containing more good news than Jonah realizes. We need not suppose that the God of the Bible is above such fooling. Think of how he plays Pharaoh in the story of the Exodus, by at first proposing just a brief trip of three days for the Israelites (like Jonah’s time in the fish!) to worship their God ... God outwits and out maneuvers him, luring him into a trap to overcome his evil ... So too with Jonah, and we can imagine ancient Israelites telling this story aloud and chuckling. It’s not as if Pharaoh, or Jonah, didn’t deserve it.”

Cary, Phillip (2008), [Jonah](#). Brazos Press. 109.

“By the end of the third chapter (in fact, as soon as v 5 tells us that the Ninevites ‘believed in God’), God becomes more playful with Jonah, more tolerant of his caustic responses, more willing to indulge his stubbornness. As we shall also see, the narrative itself becomes more whimsical; more indulgent, I may say, in that it veers from attacking issues frontally. As we observe this shift in character, mood, and temper, we begin to wonder whether God’s great deeds at sea, below waters, and within Nineveh are but mere exhibits for a prophet’s education. All these modifications will be necessary because, to the last, the narrator needs to keep Jonah oblivious of the little games that Hebrew words can play.”

Sasson, Jack M. (1995). [Jonah](#). Yale University Press. 268.

Reflection Question

What do you make of Jonah's short sermon to the Ninevites? What does Jonah not say to the Ninevites that we might expect him to say?